Someone Comes to Mind · Book One

The One Who Was Already There

Already there before I ever asked

— Before You Start 3

— Opening 7

1 Nobody Asked Me 9

2 Most of It Is Not Remembered 14

3 The Name Comes Before the Person 19

4 Bought in Advance 24

5 The First Thing Had No Price 29

6 The Back That Carried Me 35

7 The Ones Who Taught Do Not Remember 40

8 The Place Was Waiting 45

9 You See It When It Stops 50

10 It Cannot Be Repaid 56

11 So Where Does It Go 61

12 I Started Out Having Received 66

Before You Start

◆ There Are Three

This is the first of three.

Book	What it looks at
One · The One Who Was Already There	What had arrived before I ever asked
Two · The One Who Never Asked	Going toward what will not come back
Three · The One Who Stayed	What continues even when they do not know

The three look at one thing from three sides. You can read any one of them alone. Read them in order and a line joins up. The line is drawn on the covers.

◆ Every Chapter Ends With a Box

Someone Comes to Mind

Not something to do. Someone to remember.

This book does not tell you to do anything. All it does is point at something that has already happened, and it happened to you, not to me. So that box is one I cannot fill.

One person is enough. You can stop reading there. Stopping is what the box was for.

◆ Every Chapter Leaves One Thing Open

A book about love wants to close neatly. To keep myself from that, I have put one place in every chapter where I do not have the answer.

Warm writing collapses in exactly one spot: **when it pretends the painful part does not hurt.** Readers

know before the writer does. So the unresolved places in this book are left standing.

◆ And This Book Does Not Finish

There is no knot tied in the last chapter. There is none in the third book either.

That is not an oversight. **Explain everything and close it and it ends there.** I left it open because I would rather it stayed with you after you shut it.

◆ How the Facts Are Handled

Each chapter ends with a section called Where This Chapter Came From. Two things go in it: what I checked, and what I cut because I could not check it.

There is almost no outside material in this book. Numbers would have propped up some of it, but attach a number to a story like this and the story

becomes somebody else's. Anything I could not verify was cut whole rather than softened.

Opening

◆ Opening

There is one thing to clear away first. **This is not a book about how to love people well.**

Those books exist and some of them are good. They tend to start in the same place, though. How do I give so that it works. How do I give so the other person changes. How do I give so that I feel right about it. All of them are about giving with a result.

What this book looks at is the other side. **What arrived before I was in a position to ask for anything.**

A name chosen while I was still unborn. Clothes bought for a person nobody had met. A back that carried me down a road I cannot remember. None of it was requested, none of it was paid for, and most of it is not in my memory at all.

That last part is the strange one. **The bulk of what we received is gone from us.** The years in which a person is made are the years no one remembers, and the people who did the making mostly do not remember either. Ask them and they say it was nothing much.

Twelve chapters, and one question follows all twelve.

> What was here before I was?

I will not answer it in this book. I am not sure the answer belongs to me. What I can do is point at the things, one chapter at a time, and let you look.

1 · Nobody Asked Me

◆ Did Anyone Consent

Did you ever consent to being born. No. Nobody did, and you were not asked, you could not have been asked, and had anyone asked you were in no condition to answer, so the largest thing that happens to a person happens **without that person's permission.**

Sit with that and it starts to look odd. We take consent for small things. We sign forms, we tick boxes on terms we have not read, we listen to an explanation before surgery and then write our name, and yet the event that comes before all of those has no signature on it anywhere.

◆ It Was Already Ready

Here is the stranger part. Permission was never given, and still **everything was prepared.** There were clothes. Several sets, cut to fit a body that had not arrived, and there was a place to lie down, there was a name, there was a settled answer to where food would come from and how, and not one of those things existed because you said so.

So the order runs like this.

> The preparation came first. The person came after.

Not the other way round. Nobody arrived and made demands. It was all in place back when there was no one to make a demand at all.

◆ Why Do It With No Order Placed

It is worth stopping here. People prepare things for reasons, and the reasons are usually that an order

came in, or a favor was asked, or there is a cost to not doing it. The people in that room had none of the three, and more to the point, **the one who would have placed the order did not yet exist.**

They did it anyway. They had been doing it for months. You can reach for the word instinct to explain this, and it does explain it, and once it has explained it there is nothing left. Call it instinct and the hands folding a small shirt late at night disappear. I would rather not erase those hands.

◆ You Find Out Later

The one receiving knows none of it at the time. You find out much later, and the way people find out is nearly always the same. You end up preparing something for someone else, and in the middle of that you understand that you were once prepared for in the same way. That is the order it comes in. You have

to stand in the giving place before you can see what you were given.

Until then it was simply there. Like air.

◆ Is It a Debt Then

This is where I stop in this chapter.

If you received without granting permission, is that a debt. If it is a debt it has to be repaid, and if it has to be repaid then being born means starting out owing. Writing that down makes it hard to breathe. But to say it is not a debt I would have to claim there is a thing in the world you can receive and never have to pay back, and I have not seen such a thing anywhere else.

The question comes back in the tenth chapter. I do not solve it there either. One thing can be set down: the ones who did the preparing never asked to be repaid. Not once.

◆ Someone Comes to Mind

Someone prepared something for you before you arrived. Do you know who. You do not have to. Most people do not. What is certain is that the person existed, because you are here.

◆ Where This Chapter Came From

Nothing in this chapter was brought in from outside. It is what I have seen and what I thought while looking at it.

There is probably research on what households buy and spend before a birth. I considered looking and then stopped. Put a figure in and the chapter turns into a piece about what people spend on average now. The hands folding clothes that night disappear into the statistic. Those hands are what the chapter is looking at.

2 · Most of It Is Not Remembered

◆ Before Three

There is a point at which a person starts to remember their own life, usually somewhere around three or four, and before that point the person was already living. Eating, crying, sleeping, being held. Which means everyone has **several years of being alive with no memory of it.** Try counting what happened in those years and you run out of breath. Fed six or seven times a day, changed about as often, somebody up several times a night. A year is thousands of times. A few years is well past ten thousand.

Every one of those ten thousand is gone.

◆ They Did Not Vanish

There is an easy thought to fall into here: that if it is not remembered it might as well not have happened. It is not so. What was received in those years stays in the body, and a person who was held is different from a person who was not, and a person whose crying brought someone is different from a person whose crying brought no one. **The one who received cannot remember, and the result remains.**

That is the strangest thing in this chapter. A large share of what made a person sits outside that person's memory. They do not know how they came to be the way they are.

◆ So There Is No Way to Be Grateful

With no memory there is no gratitude. Gratitude runs on memory. You have to know what somebody did for you before you can thank them. And the stretch in which you received the most is blank from end to

end, and so people live out their lives **unable to be grateful for the largest thing they were ever given.**

It is an odd arrangement and nobody says so, because everyone is living inside it. The ones who gave know it too. Lifting a child at night, they know the child will not remember this. They know and they do it. That is the seventh chapter.

◆ What Does Get Remembered Is Small

What does stay is stranger still. The childhood people remember is mostly small things. The light on some particular afternoon. One sentence somebody said. A road walked holding a hand. The big things do not stay and the small ones do. I do not know why, though I can guess at part of it. The big things were continuous and the small ones happened once. What is continuous becomes background, and background is not remembered. What is always there is the hardest thing to see.

◆ What Do You Do With an Empty Place

Here is where I get stuck. If you received it and have no memory of it, what are you supposed to do with that. Treating it as nothing will not work, because the result is still here. Being grateful will not work either, because no one comes to mind, and you could ask, except it is usually too late, and when it is not, the person you ask does not remember much either.

Leaving it empty seems to be the only option.
Though leaving it empty while knowing it is empty is probably not the same as simply not knowing. What the difference amounts to I cannot write down.

◆ Someone Comes to Mind

Someone lifted you up at an hour you cannot remember. Have you ever asked who it was. If there is still someone alive to ask, they will not remember well either. Ask anyway. Something surfaces on their side.

◆ Where This Chapter Came From

Nothing in this chapter was brought in from outside.

When childhood memory begins, and how what came before it persists afterward, have certainly been studied. The three-or-four figure comes from that direction as far as I know. I have not read the original, so the chapter says *usually* and nothing more. To use a number I would have to read the source, and even then I am not sure this chapter would need it.

The feedings and changes per day were not counted either. They are the range anyone would recognize, which is why the chapter says six or seven, and thousands.

3 · The Name Comes Before the Person

◆ Nobody Chose It

Of everything that stays attached to a person for life, there is one thing **the person did not pick.** The name. A name is settled before the one who will carry it arrives, sometimes months before, sometimes earlier still and then held in waiting, and it is made at a time when nobody knows what sort of person this will be.

So a name carries no information about its owner. What a name holds is **the mind of the one who made it.**

◆ There Is a Wish Inside

Watch people choosing a name and they all do roughly the same things. They look for a good meaning. They say it aloud to hear how it sits. They wonder whether it will get the child teased. And they hesitate for a long time. Days. Weeks, in a lot of houses.

What is inside that hesitation is a wish. How they would like this child to turn out. **A wish laid in advance on someone who has not yet done anything.** And the wish has no condition on it. No household says do this and then you get the name. It is given first.

◆ Every Time It Is Called, the Wish Goes By

There is something a name does that nobody notices. Every time it is spoken, the wish inside it passes through once more. The speaker almost never knows. They are calling someone to dinner, asking where

they are going. And the sound carries the whole of what was put into it at the start.

Which is why names do not wear out. Called ten thousand times, what was placed in them first is still there.

◆ Changing It Does Not Remove It

Some people change their name. The meaning does not suit them, the sound grates, a different name has come to fit the life. Changing it does not make the first one disappear. The fact that someone made that name and waited with it does not change. Afterward it remains a thing that happened.

That is what this chapter is looking at. Among the things we receive, there are some that cannot be given back, and either there is no one left to take them, or they are not the kind of thing that can be returned.

◆ What If It Was Not a Good Name

Here is where this gets stuck.

I wrote that a name holds a wish, and for some people that wish is heavy. A name made so they would become like somebody. A name made to carry on something in the family. From the receiving end those names are a weight. I could not read this chapter aloud to such a person as it stands.

Then I should write down where a wish ends and a weight begins, and I tried several times and deleted it, and the same name is a wish in one house and a weight in another. What divides them seems to be the sentences that came after, not the name, and I cannot put those sentences here, so I am leaving it.

◆ Someone Comes to Mind

Someone made your name. Have you ever heard why that one. If you have not, it is worth thinking about

whether there is still a person you could ask. The story is usually short, and short things of that kind stay for a long time.

◆ Where This Chapter Came From

Nothing in this chapter was brought in from outside. What people look for when naming a child is written at the range anyone would recognize, with no research behind it. I considered a passage on how naming differs between countries and cut it. That direction turns the chapter into a piece about custom, and what it is looking at is those few months of having made a name and waiting.

4 · Bought in Advance

◆ The Smallest Size

Baby clothes carry sizes marked in months. Newborn, three months, six months. The smallest of them is the one worn least. It is outgrown in a few weeks. The thing chosen after the longest look is the thing used for the shortest time.

There is one place in the house where those clothes sit, and everything in it is small, everything is new, nothing has been used. And the one who filled that place has never seen the face of the one who will use it. Guessing sizes and picking colors and thinking about which season it will be, all for a face nobody has seen, resembles no other transaction in the world.

◆ Preparing Is a Bet

Preparation is another word for believing. Nobody buys in advance unless they believe the person is coming. And the ground under that belief is thin. Nobody actually knows, and in some houses the person does not come. They buy anyway. They buy without having worked out what would be done with the things if the person never arrived.

So preparing is **putting something down on what does not yet exist.** The one who puts it down can lose. The one it was for may never learn that it happened, and people have been doing this for thousands of years, and the houses that do it far outnumber the houses that do not.

◆ The Things That Went Unused

Not everything prepared gets used. There is the outfit outgrown before it fit. The thing that never came out because the season turned wrong. The thing bought

and then forgotten. Those stay at the bottom of the drawer.

What went unused was preparation all the same. While that shirt sat there somebody was picturing a person wearing it, and the picturing changed those few months in that house, and what never reached the receiver had already happened on the giving side. This comes back in the second book.

◆ It Keeps Happening After They Are Grown

None of this is only about babies.

Parents go on buying things after a child has left home. They buy what the child used to like, thinking they will come at the holiday, and when nobody comes it sits there. Next holiday they buy it again. If a friend says they are coming, out comes the thing that friend liked, and the house gets cleaned from the morning of the day. The guest has not arrived and the house is already a house with a guest in it.

People move ahead of time toward whoever they love. It is hard to explain and it is plainly so.

◆ What If the Preparation Is Refused

Here is where this chapter stops.

What happens when the thing bought in advance is not wanted. More commonly, when it simply goes unused. The one who prepared feels it, and the one who received does not know why the air changed. What gets said is usually about the object, and both of them know it is not about the object.

So some people prepare less. They stop buying ahead so as not to be hurt. That looks like wisdom from one angle and like losing something from another, and I have not settled which.

◆ Someone Comes to Mind

Someone bought something for you before you came.

Do you know where that thing is now. If you still have one of them, today would be a reasonable day to take it out and look at it. That object has never once asked whether you deserved it.

◆ Where This Chapter Came From

Nothing in this chapter was brought in from outside.

There is probably research on what households prepare before a birth and what it costs. I did not look. A figure turns this into a chapter about spending, and then the unworn clothes at the bottom of the drawer become unsold stock. The unsold stock is what the chapter is looking at.

5 · The First Thing Had No Price

◆ Put This Down First

The first thing a person ever received had no price on it.

There is a reason to say that at the start. Nearly every exchange we know has a price attached, so it takes a moment to call to mind an exchange that has none. Goods have a cost. Help carries a share to be returned later. Even a gift sets off some arithmetic on the receiving side. And the things received in a person's first years had none of that arithmetic anywhere in them.

◆ Milk Comes With No Invoice

Think about an infant being fed and something odd shows.

The child pays nothing, has nothing to pay with, does not know how paying works, and does not know it is receiving, and the one giving gets up several times a night and sometimes wrecks their health, and writes no invoice. Not once. And nobody writes a note to collect the same amount back once the child has grown.

So this is not a trade. To call it a trade both sides would need arithmetic, and only one side has any, and that side does not do it, and what the right name for it is I still do not know. What can be set down is that the first exchange a person meets in the world has this shape. **We meet the exchange without arithmetic first, and then we enter a world that runs on arithmetic.**

◆ When Prices Start Appearing

Then one day prices appear.

Run an errand and something comes back. Do well and praise arrives. Do not and it does not. From there the child learns to count. This much done brings that much back. Learning it is not a bad thing. Not learning it makes the world very hard to live in.

Only, once it is learned, what came before goes out of view. To someone who knows the arithmetic, the years of receiving without any is neither remembered nor explicable, and so the grown person comes to believe every exchange has a price, and with that belief starts recalculating everything they ever received.

◆ Putting a Price on It Changes It

Something curious happens when you price what you were given.

The moment it has a number it becomes a debt, and a debt sits heavy, and what sits heavy you want to avoid. Which is how it happens that someone who received a great deal keeps their distance from the one who gave. It is not dislike. The sum simply got too large to look at.

The giving side mostly does not follow this. They never put a price on anything. One side did no arithmetic and one side did, and only the side that did the arithmetic is suffering.

◆ So Should We Not Count

Here is the stuck place.

Not counting at all is strange too. Someone who does not know they received has no gratitude, and without gratitude there is nothing to pass to the next person. But counting makes a debt, and a debt makes distance.

There ought to be a road where you know you received and never assign a figure, and I cannot write down how that is done. I suspect the people who manage it are doing it right now. I have never heard one of them explain it.

◆ Someone Comes to Mind

Someone has never asked you what it cost. They are still not asking. Their not counting made things easy for you, and that it was not free is something you only see much later.

◆ Where This Chapter Came From

Nothing in this chapter was brought in from outside. It is what I have seen and what I thought while looking at it.

There is likely research putting a number on the labor of feeding. I did not use it. The moment it is

converted into hours the chapter turns over. This chapter is looking at the side where no price gets assigned, and bringing in a source that assigned one would mean I did the arithmetic first.

6 · The Back That Carried Me

◆ A Back Nobody Chose

Nobody chooses the back that carries them, and nobody knows whether it was broad or narrow, young or already bent, sweating or not. You were up there and you went somewhere, and on the way you fell asleep, and when you woke you were somewhere else, and the road is missing from the memory of the one carried while the weight stays in the body of the one who carried.

◆ The Weight Is All on One Side

That is the shape of carrying. The weight goes on one side only.

The one carried is light. Their feet are off the ground, so there is nowhere to put any effort, and with no effort to make they fall asleep, and the one carrying is heavier by exactly that much. Two people are going somewhere and one of them is producing all of the force, and the carrier does not propose splitting it, partly because it cannot be split, and partly because proposing it would make the thing stop being carrying.

What is strange is that the one carried feels no guilt about it. A four-year-old on a father's back is not apologizing. There is an age at which that is not strange, and after that age it becomes strange. Where the line sits is the odd part. Nobody was ever taught it and everybody knows.

◆ The Carried Place Comes Back

Being carried does not end with childhood.

Too ill to walk and someone holds you up. Fallen and someone gets you to your feet. Work collapses and someone props you for months. Each time the weight goes to one side only, and the side it goes to tends not to talk about it, and people who carry generally do not make much of it out loud.

So there is a separate moment, later, when the one carried learns the size of what happened. It arrives after they have carried someone themselves. Carrying makes your back hurt, and only once it hurts does the thought come: **that back must have hurt too.** The thought nearly always comes too late.

◆ You Cannot See a Back's Face

Being carried has one particular feature. You cannot see the face of the one carrying you.

So the one carried does not know whether this is hard. There is no expression to read. There is only a

voice, and a voice can be arranged. Told that it is fine, you understand it to be fine.

There are many other places built the same way, where the receiver cannot see the giver's face. Most of what this book is looking at sits in places like that. Places where the one who received never finds out.

◆ Should the Carrying Be Mentioned

Here is the unresolved place.

What happens if the one who carried brings it up. *I carried you like that for years* is true, and it is true, and the instant it is said the weight transfers to the one who was carried. It can become gratitude and it can become debt, and which it will become is not known even to the person saying it.

So a great many people never bring it up. Not bringing it up means the other never knows. Bringing

it up moves the weight. Both are a loss and I cannot pick the better one.

◆ Someone Comes to Mind

There was a back that carried you.

Do you know whose it was. You do not have to. What is certain is that you did not walk here on your own. For the first few years you could not take a single step.

◆ Where This Chapter Came From

Nothing in this chapter was brought in from outside.

I considered writing about how carrying differs between countries, or how far back the practice goes, and cut it. That direction turns the chapter into a piece about custom, and what it is looking at is the structure where the weight lands on one side only.

7 · The Ones Who Taught Do Not Remember

◆ How Many Times Was It

Have you ever thought about how many repetitions it takes for a person to learn to speak.

A single word takes dozens. Heard and heard again, copied wrong, corrected, wrong again, corrected again. And there are thousands of words. Multiply it out and the number gets so large that counting stops meaning anything. One thing is certain though. **Somebody absorbed every one of those tens of thousands.**

And that person does not remember it. Which attempt produced the first *mama*, which word took longest, what got corrected on which evening. One or two scenes survive and the rest is gone.

◆ Neither Side Remembers

The second chapter said the receiving side does not remember. This chapter is the other side of it. **The giving side does not remember either.**

So the tens of thousands of repetitions that made a person are missing from both memories. It plainly happened and nobody holds the scene. An event with no witness, and the result is inside the head of whoever is reading this sentence, and that you know what these letters mean is the result of those tens of thousands.

◆ Repetition Does Not Stay

There is a guess available for why it does not stay. Repeated things do not stay in memory.

What happened once stays, and what happens daily becomes background. So a person's memory holds the special days and omits the ordinary ones that

actually made them. Memory summarizes, and the first thing a summary throws out is repetition.

That is a little unfair. The thing done most is the thing that survives least. The thousands of meals cooked do not stay and one meal out somewhere does. Of those two, the one that kept the person alive is the first.

◆ So Gratitude Lands Wrong

Something slips out of line here.

Gratitude goes to what can be remembered. The special thing, the visible thing, the thing that happened once. And what was actually received in quantity sits on the opposite side. So a person's gratitude always lands on **the smaller portion of what they were given.**

This is not a failing of character, it is how memory is built. There is nowhere to lay the blame, which

makes it the more frustrating kind of error.

◆ What Do You Do With Something That Will Not Total

Here is the unsolved place.

There is no way to learn the size of what you received. Counting fails for want of records. Asking fails because the giver does not remember. Estimating fails because the figure will not hold still, and so you go on not knowing, and going on not knowing, a day arrives when it feels like you were given nothing.

Keeping the sentence *I received a great deal* and leaving the amount blank seems to be all there is. We are back at the same place as the fifth chapter. Second time here and it still does not open.

◆ Someone Comes to Mind

Someone taught you to speak. That person does not remember doing it. Ask them and they will say they just did it. Inside that *just* are tens of thousands of times.

◆ Where This Chapter Came From

Nothing in this chapter was brought in from outside.

How many exposures a child needs to learn one word has been studied, as far as I know. **I have not read the original, so the chapter says only dozens, and the thousands and the tens of thousands are estimates at that same level.** The numbers are not the frame of the chapter, but it would be worth propping them up before publication.

The same goes for repetition staying less well in memory. It is written at the range anyone would recognize, with no source behind it.

8 · The Place Was Waiting

◆ Picking Up What the Last Chapter Could Not Count

The last chapter said there is no way to count the size of what we received. Let me take one step further from there. Part of why it cannot be counted is that **it was already there before it arrived.**

To count something received you need a moment of receipt. You have to be able to write down that on such a date you were given such a thing, and the things this book is looking at have no moment of receipt. They were already in place before I got there.

◆ A Place Exists Before the Person

Think of the first day at school. There was already a place. A desk, a number, a slot for a name tag.

Nobody told any of the children who had made the place ready, and no child asked. A place looks like something that was simply always there.

Work is the same. First morning and there is a desk, an account on the system, a chair to sit in. Somebody set that up the night before. That somebody is usually a stranger, and it is rare to ever find out who.

People always walk into places that somebody arrived earlier and made. Once you have noticed it once, the world looks slightly different. Roads are like that. Letters are like that. Food is like that. All of it done by someone before I came.

◆ There Is Waiting Inside

A place has waiting inside it. To make a place ready is to wait for whoever is coming.

Waiting is invisible. Once it is over it leaves no mark. The moment a person sits down, the whole stretch

during which the place stood empty disappears. So the one who sits does not know the place was waiting for them. They think the place was there.

The third book has a chapter that looks only at waiting. That one looks at the times nobody comes. This one looks only at the times they do.

◆ It Is There for Latecomers Too

There is one good thing about the place coming first.

Arrive late and the place is still there, and to give a different place to the punctual and the late you would have to be keeping track of who came when, and a place made in advance does no such arithmetic. The ones preparing it do not know the arrival time of whoever is coming.

So even someone who arrives very late comes and sits. That there exist places where nobody asks why you are only coming now is strangely reassuring.

◆ And the People Who Had No Place

This is the stuck place. Some people had no place. People who walked into somewhere nobody had prepared, who arrived and found nothing. Read this chapter to them and it turns cruel.

I have not yet made anything I could say to them. *There must have been one somewhere* might be a lie. Saying nothing makes this a chapter written for half of the people. Of everywhere I got caught while writing this book, this is where I got caught most often.

◆ Someone Comes to Mind

Somebody made ready the place you walked into. School or work or a house. Have you ever tried to find out who it was. Mostly you cannot. Not being able to find out is part of the nature of the thing.

◆ Where This Chapter Came From

Nothing in this chapter was brought in from outside.

There is certainly a great deal of research on people who had no place. I did not use it. Bring that material in here and those people become a statistic, which is the exact opposite of what the chapter was trying to say, and I left the place empty instead and wrote that I could not fill it.

9 · You See It When It Stops

◆ The Phrase About Not Knowing How to Be Grateful

There is a phrase about people who receive and do not know how to be grateful. It is usually said to scold someone. This chapter disagrees with it. **It is not that they do not know how. It is that it cannot be seen.** While you are receiving, it is built so as not to show.

There is one way to make it show, and it is not a good way. It shows when it stops.

◆ You Learn by the Cut

Think of a morning with no hot water.

Nobody is grateful for hot water on an ordinary day. You turn the tap and it comes. But on the morning it does not come you think about it all day. It becomes vivid only once it is gone. So that gratitude arrives during the absence, not during the having. Not while receiving. When it is cut off.

People work the same way. Someone who is always there steps out once, and only then does everything they were doing become visible, and no meal appears, no call comes, something is not where it should be. One day away is enough.

◆ So the Constant Person Loses

There is something unfair built into this.

The more constantly someone is there, the less they are seen. The steady person is the least thanked and the occasional visitor stands out more. What the once-a-year guest brought stays in memory, and what the daily person did becomes background.

So the person who does the most in a house ends up the least visible. Until they fall ill. After that it is all visible within a day. Learning it that way is late and the price is high.

◆ A Way to See It Earlier

I have wondered whether there is a way to see it before it is gone.

One is imagining. Sketching out what today would be like without this person. Try it and it comes up surprisingly clear. Only, imagining does not last, and within days it has sunk back into background.

The other is asking. Ask what they did today and it becomes visible. Do not ask and it does not. This works better than imagining and is harder by the same amount.

◆ What Shows After a Death

The commonest case is that it shows after a death.

What people say after a funeral is nearly always the same. That now they understand. The expression on their faces when they say it is closer to bewilderment than to grief, and it is the face of someone finding out that what was in front of them went unseen the whole time.

The seventh chapter of the third book is about that. It looks at what remains after the person is gone. This one records only that it takes the going to make it seen.

◆ So Am I Supposed to Watch It Every Day

Here is the place I cannot solve.

Is there anyone who lives conscious at all times of what they are receiving. Probably not. Live like that and the day will not move. A person needs the capacity to take things for granted in order to get on

to the next thing. You cannot breathe while attending to the air.

So the not-seeing looks like the design rather than a fault, and if that is so I do not know when gratitude is supposed to happen. Taking it out occasionally seems to be the only option, and how occasional that occasionally should be I cannot write down.

◆ Someone Comes to Mind

There is someone always there beside you right now.

Sketch out, just once, what your day would have been without them today. It does not take long. And having sketched it, this evening is slightly different.

◆ Where This Chapter Came From

Nothing in this chapter was brought in from outside.

The business of learning the size of a thing only after it is gone may well have a name and a body of study behind it. I did not look. The instant it has a name this becomes a chapter that explains, and what it is looking at is that morning with no hot water.

10 · It Cannot Be Repaid

◆ Has Anyone Repaid It

Has anyone repaid what they received from a parent.

No. Plenty of people have worked at it. Given money, bought a house, driven them to hospital, stayed beside them to the end. Ask those people and not one of them says they repaid it. They all say they could not. The harder someone worked at it, the more firmly they say so.

The question from the first chapter comes back here. There it was whether this is a debt. Here it is whether it can be paid.

◆ Why It Will Not Settle

A few reasons.

One is that the amount is unknown. As the earlier chapters showed, there is no way to count the size of what was received. With no amount there is no paying in full. Give whatever you like and you cannot tell whether that was all of it, so no receipt is ever issued.

One is that the kinds do not match, and what was received was mostly time and body, and what gets returned is mostly money or things, and the two do not convert, so no sum however large becomes the same thing.

And one is direction. **When you received it they were young, and when you return it they are old.** It looks like giving back to the same person, and the one who gave and the one receiving the return are not the same person. Time went through the middle.

◆ The Other Side Will Not Take It

Here is the oddest part of this place. Try to repay and the other side refuses.

Give money and it comes back into your pocket. Buy something and you are asked why you spent that much. Say thank you and you are told it is nothing. They will not let you repay. So there is a debt and the counter is closed.

Why they do it is guessable. Accepting repayment would make it a trade. The giving side does not want it to be a trade. The moment they take it, the past several decades become an invoice.

◆ So What Do People Do

There is one thing people do when they have received something that cannot be repaid.

They send it sideways. Unable to return it to the giver, they give it to someone else. To a child, to

someone younger, to a stranger. Those people never gave them anything, and they do it anyway.

This behavior does not explain. It makes no arithmetic sense. Receive from A and give to B and the account with A sits exactly where it was. And people do it, and having done it they are strangely lighter.

The next chapter is about that.

◆ The Regret Does Not Go

Here is the stuck place.

Sending it sideways does not remove the regret. However much you give to someone else, what you failed to give them stays exactly as it was. Which is why the regret of people who have buried a parent never shrinks across a whole life, and I have not found anything to say that would shrink it, and I do

not want to write a paragraph here that pretends I have.

◆ Someone Comes to Mind

There is someone you did not repay.

If they are still alive, today a phone call will do. If they are not, you may leave it unpaid. Not being repayable is the nature of the thing, and they never meant to collect in the first place.

◆ Where This Chapter Came From

Nothing in this chapter was brought in from outside.

There is certainly research, country by country, on what people give their parents. I did not use it. Once a figure appears the chapter becomes arithmetic, and this chapter is looking at the side where the arithmetic does not close.

11 · So Where Does It Go

◆ The Conclusion First

What was received goes sideways. It cannot go backward, so it goes sideways.

The last chapter said the repayment counter is closed. You would expect what was received to pool there, and it does not, and people send what they received off somewhere, and when the somewhere cannot be the giver they send it to someone else. Nobody taught this and nearly everybody does it.

◆ It Goes Toward the Younger

The direction leans. Mostly it goes toward whoever is younger.

Someone who received from a parent gives to a child. Someone taught by a teacher teaches a student. Someone who was shown the work on their first day shows the new arrival. It steps down a generation at a time. So what was received does not stay put but keeps descending, and nobody along the way recovers the principal.

The structure is strange. Nobody is repaid and it keeps circulating. Look at each person separately and every one of them is at a loss. Look at the whole and it does not break.

◆ What Is Not Returned Travels Further

There is one more strange thing.

An exchange that is returned ends between the two of them. Lend and be repaid and that is the end; the account closes on the spot. An exchange that is not returned does not end. The one who received sends it

to another, and that one sends it again. **Because it is not repaid, it travels a long way.**

So being unrepayable may not have been a defect. Built to be repaid it would have stopped there. Built so it cannot be, it kept going. Setting it down like that feels a touch too neat, and I have not found another way to account for it.

◆ Passing It On Makes You Lighter

A person who has only received is heavy. The regret from the last chapter is that weight. And once they have given to somebody, the weight drops.

I do not know why it drops. It is not that the account balanced. What is owed to A does not disappear by giving to B. And people really do get lighter. That is probably why those who have raised a child start to see their own parents a little differently, and doing it is what shows you the size, and once the size is

visible the regret turns partly into gratitude. Not entirely. A little.

◆ And the People Who Received Nothing

Here is the place I cannot solve.

What becomes of someone who received little. Someone with nothing to pass on. If what was received is what flows, then someone who received nothing is naturally unable to give. Written out like that it becomes a piece that gives up far too easily.

And in fact there are people who received nothing and give. I have seen people who give more. Then the flowing model is wrong, and I have not found what is more nearly right. The question comes back in the second book. I do not expect to solve it there either.

◆ Someone Comes to Mind

There was a time you passed on what you had received.

Does it come to you who it went to. That person had never given you anything. You gave anyway. You probably still cannot explain why.

◆ Where This Chapter Came From

Nothing in this chapter was brought in from outside.

There is likely research on what is handed down across generations. I did not use it. Bring a model in and people become variables, and what this chapter is looking at is the behavior people keep performing without any explanation for it.

12 · I Started Out Having Received

◆ Counting It Up

Eleven chapters have gone by. Counted up, it comes to this.

Received without permission, and most of it absent from memory. A name made before arrival. Things bought when there was nobody to use them. A first gift with no price on it. Carried by somebody over a road walked by no step of your own. Tens of thousands of repetitions teaching speech, missing from both memories. A place made ready by someone who got there first. Invisible for as long as it is still arriving. And it cannot be repaid. So it goes sideways.

Shortened to one line it is one sentence.

> I started out having received.

◆ What That Sentence Does

It looks obvious. It looks obvious, and once you have believed it, a few things quietly shift.

The assumption that what I hold was mine to begin with comes loose. Then giving something up stops feeling like a loss, because it was received in the first place. And looking at what somebody else holds shifts a little too. The thought arrives that they also started out having received.

It is not a large change. Nobody becomes a different person overnight. Only, at every place where you are about to weigh something, there is now one beat. That one beat is everything this book has to offer.

◆ And It Does Not End Here

This book ties no knot.

It cannot. Across eleven chapters eleven unresolved places have stacked up, and the largest of them is still sitting there untouched. Where did what we received come from.

Say it came from parents and the question follows: who did they receive from. Step back a generation at a time and the line keeps going backward. At no point does a place appear where you could say **it began here.** Everyone along it is somebody who received and handed on.

Where that line began I do not know. That is why the line drawn on the cover comes in from off the page. The beginning is not inside the picture.

◆ Toward the Second Book

Looking only at the receiving side filled twelve chapters. And what is received does not sit still. It

goes sideways, in the direction the eleventh chapter showed.

The second book looks at that side. Going without asking the price. Going where nothing comes back. Going without weighing whether anyone deserves it. Watch what people do there and it explains even less than what we saw on the receiving side.

Set the two covers side by side and the line joins. The line that reached a single point in the first book sets out again in the second. That point is you.

◆ Someone Comes to Mind

One person has kept coming to mind while you read this.

You do not have to have said anything to them yet. Having thought of them is enough for today. They do not know that you did, and without their knowing it, the thing has already happened.

◆ Where This Chapter Came From

Nothing in this chapter was brought in from outside. It stands on what the preceding eleven chapters brought.

The near-absence of outside material in this book was deliberate, and there were several places a number could have propped something up, and a number turns the person in that place into a statistic. Where to put one and where not to was a decision taken each time, and the trace of each decision is at the end of each chapter.

The One Who Was Already There · Someone Comes to Mind · Book One